USSR against the US, later with the US against the USSR, and finally, after the Cold War, with Russia against the US.

The history of India's and China's relations with the USSR/Russia and the US also shows that while India and China sought partnerships with those powers for their own security, they were used in turn by Moscow and Washington for their own purposes. During the Cold War, the USSR and the US each wooed China to side with them against the other. Both powers tried to recruit India against each other and against China. If India and China ended up on opposite sides in global history, it was often because the almost inexorable logic of power balancing (and ideology preferences) in the India–China–US–USSR quadrilateral shaped Indian and Chinese choices. To some extent, then, India and China have come to look at each other warily for reasons beyond their bilateral quarrels.

Finally, our global history of India, China, the USSR/Russia, and the US shows that change is the only constant. Sometimes, change was endogenous, resulting from one party or more making decisions about who their friends and enemies were; and sometimes it was exogenous, being the consequence of developments outside the four-power system. The Czech revolt of 1968 sparked a Soviet intervention that further antagonized and alienated Beijing from Moscow. The East Pakistani turmoil in 1970–71 ended in the creation of Bangladesh, but at the geopolitical level it gave the US an opportunity to woo China and it pushed India into the arms of the USSR. Developments in Afghanistan in the late 1970s that led to the Soviet invasion, and in turn to a deeper partnership between China and the US, was another exogenously induced shift. The 9/11 attacks on the US is yet another instance which for a decade brought India, China, and Russia into a degree of alignment with the US against Islamic extremism.

What this suggests is that while the present partnership of India with the US and of China with Russia seems durable, endogenous and exogenous developments could alter the strategic landscape. With Joe Biden in the White House, the US could rethink the relationship with China and decide to work with rather than against it. A crisis in mainland China–Taiwan relations or between the two Koreas could have profound consequences for